

Audio-Technica ATH-SQ1TW

Musical but lacking on the feature front

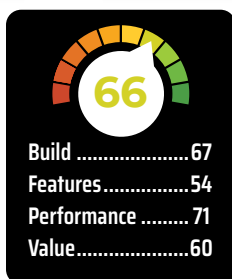


Tokyo-based Audio-Technica is a legendary name in the audio space. I've tested headphones and earphones from this brand and have usually come away impressed. This time around, the company has brought a new entrant to the competitive TWS space in India dubbed the Audio-Technica ATH-SQ1TW.

These no-nonsense buds promise to deliver a musical experience, but this could come at the cost of features. At a similar price point, you get options such as the Jabra Elite 4, Google Pixel Buds A-Series, and for ₹2,500 more, you can get even the shiny new Nothing Ear (2). So, is the Audio-Technica ATH-SQ1TW worth its asking price of ₹7,490 and how does it hold up against the competition? Let's find out in my detailed review of the Audio-Technica ATH-SQ1TW.

DESIGN AND FIT

Audio-Technica has positioned the new ATH-SQ1TW as a stylish pair of truly wireless earphones; available



for purchase in several colourways. Sadly, this is not the case in the Indian market where the Audio-Technica ATH-SQ1TW is only available in the Black colour variant, which honestly, looks quite bland compared to the suave looks of the Jabra Elite 4 and Google Pixel Buds A-Series. And of course, it looks nowhere as cool as the Nothing Ear (2).

However, there are some design flourishes of note. The earbuds sit in a square charging box with rounded corners and subtle Audio-Technica branding on the top. The matte black case looks decent for the price and the shape is quite unconventional, but as we mentioned before, there are better-looking truly wireless earbuds at the same price. The USB Type-C charging port is situated on the back alongside a white LED indicator.

When you open the case, you will see the buds neatly tucked into their assigned Right and Left slots which are clearly indicated via text. The magnets are strong and the buds don't slip out easily. The hinge of the case, however, feels a bit flimsy and

could be prone to breakage with rough usage, so be warned.

The earbuds follow the same squarish design language, as the charging case, and feature tiny Audio-Technica logos on the back (which also doubles as a touch sensor). There's an extra fin-like area jutting out from each earbud which is merely ornamental and doesn't help with the fit. Instead, it houses LED-lit R and L logos that light up when placed inside the case or when the case is opened. This looks pretty fancy.

How these earbuds will fit you depends entirely on the fit you get from the ear tips. Audio-Technica has provided a total of 4 sizes of eartips, so most users should find a suitable fit. I found the fit to be quite snug and secure, but the earbuds go in very deep into your ears, which some may find uncomfortable. The buds need to be twisted and locked into place to get a solid fit. I could even go jogging with these buds without having to adjust them often and they also are IPX4 rated – which means you get resistance against sweat and splash damage.

FEATURES

For the asking price of ₹7,490, the Audio-Technica ATH-SQ1TW are surprisingly low on features. There's no Active Noise Cancellation, no app support, no voice assistant control, no on-ear detection, no multipoint connection, and no wireless charging. Most of its competitors come with at least ANC and app support at this price, so sadly, the Audio-Technica ATH-SQ1TW feels very barebones.

Let's talk about the features we do get. The Audio-Technica ATH-SQ1TW may lack ANC but it does come packing a Transparency Mode. This can be activated by long-pressing the right touch sensor. Sadly, this mode is not well-implemented. As soon as you turn it on, you will be presented with a soft static-like noise and the environmental sounds that are amplified sound very artificial.